> transcription of the farmans on the appropriate paper and with the designated seal could take days, even months.

This elaborate system made impetuous decisions much more difficult to make, and the scribes, for their part, took care not to accidentally step on the Padshah's shadow, a most boorish act.

The writing, sending, and receiving of these royal messages were elaborate tasks themselves, since it was the sacrosanct word of the Padshah or his family that was being conveyed. A command from the emperor himself was called a hukm*, while commands issued by the other members of the royal family were called nishans. The elaborate ways in which farmans were folded, the seals, the paper, were all part of the ritual of authority, meant to convey the imperial presence in absentia.

> The farman is folded so that both corners touch, then a paper knot is tied and then sealed in so that the contents are not visible. The sealing gum is made from the sap of kunar, bar, pipal and other trees which, like wax, becomes soft when warmed, but hardens when cold. After the farman has been sealed, it is placed in a golden envelope, for His Majesty regards the use of such external signs of greatness as a service to God.

Nor could the recipient of such an exalted farman irreverently rip it open. He would have to halt before the messenger at a certain distance, in a suitably submissive manner, place the document upon his head, prostrate himself, and then give the messenger an apt reward for his service. A particular honour was when the Padshah might affix his fingerprint upon the document, as when he pardoned a Rajput chieftain for some misbehaviour.

While Akbar was bringing in these profound and long-lasting changes in Mughal administration, as we have seen, the Mughal forces under Munim Khan and Todar Mal in Bihar and Bengal had achieved stunning successes against the Afghan forces of Daud Khan. 'A tremendous battle took place,' wrote Badauni, 'when the elephants of Daud (all of which were fed on good grass and were madder than can be imagined) were put into motion.' In the Battle of Tukaroi, in southern Midnapur district, the eighty-year-old Chaghatai warlord, Munim Khan, fought with furious bravery, lashing out at Gujar Khan Afghan with a whip when he found his sword-